Country Profile: Tanzania

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 24
- Plurality religion: Christianity
- Official language: None
- Official religion: None
- Core group: None

Historical Background

The modern Tanzanian state gained independence from British rule in 1961. In 1964, following the ratification of the Articles of Union, the regions of Tanganyika—representing what is now mainland Tanzania—and the island archipelago of Zanzibar were united to form the United Republic of Tanzania. What NBP lists as Tanzania is therefore Tanganyika between 1961 and 1963 and the united territory of Tanganyika and the islands of Zanzibar from 1964 onwards.

Groups

Tanzania is home to over 100 ethnic groups, although the precise number remains uncertain since the national census does not provide disaggregation by ethnicity or religion.[1] The NBP group list for Tanzania consists of 24 groups. The groups are primarily ethno-linguistic, which is why in most cases the group name matches the language spoken.

Despite the ethno-linguistic fragmentation of Tanzania, NBP does not refer to any group as a politically dominant or "core" group for the period 1961–2020. Ethnicity has not played a significant role since independence, and no ethnic group holds a demographic majority.[2]

For clarity, the description of groups is divided into mainland groups, which are located in mainland Tanzania, and those concentrated on the islands of Zanzibar.

[1] Minority Rights, 2024a.
[2] EPR, 2021.

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The population of mainland Tanzania is primarily Christian, whilst the population of Zanzibar is almost exclusively Muslim.[3]

- Mainland groups represent around 98% of Tanzania's population. Most adhere to Christianity, including the **Chagga, Gogo, Ha, Hehe, Luo, Nyakusa, Sukuma, Ngoni-Bena, Rungwa-Fipa, Kuria-Datoga, Haya-Zinza,** and **Nyilamba-Nyaturu**. Among these, the **Sukuma** (13%), **Gogo** (4%), and **Ha** (4%) are the largest three.[4] Except for the Chagga, who speak Mochi, all other groups speak languages corresponding to their names.
- A number of mainland groups also follow Islam, including the **Nyamwezi**, **Mwera**, **Shambala**, **Yao**, **Zaramo**, and smaller subgroups such as the Ngingo, Rangi, and Subi, who together represent 9% of the population and are classified under **Other Mainland Muslims** by NBP.[5] The largest Islam-practicing communities are the Zaramo (11%), Yao (10%), and Nyamwezi (5%). [6] As with the Christian groups above, these groups also speak languages that align with their group names.
- Mainland Tanzania is also home to the **Maasai**, considered an indigenous group of Tanzania whose traditional territories stretch from the Rift Valley lakes of Kenya into Tanzania.[7] They are distinct from other groups, as they practice their traditional religions. The group speaks Maasai and constitutes approximately 1% of the population.[8]
- Finally, mainland Tanzania is also home to **Asians**, who represent slightly less than 1% of the population.[9] This group includes the Gujrati, Chinese, and Kacchi subgroups and is notable for its diversity, with members speaking a variety of languages and practicing different religions.
- In the Zanzibar archipelago, which represents around 2% of Tanzania's total population, the demographic landscape is primarily composed of two groups: **Zanzibar Africans** (also known as **Shirazi**) and **Zanzibar Arabs**. The Zanzibar Africans/Shirazi make up approximately 1% of Tanzania's

[3] Minority Rights, 2024a.
[4] AMAR, 2023.
[5] Ibid.
[6] Ibid.
[7] Minority Rights, 2024b.
[8] AMAR 2023; Minority Rights, 2024b.
[9] African Studies Centre, 2024.

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population, while the Zanzibar Arabs constitute about 0.5%.[10] Zanzibar Arabs have historically held significant economic and political influence. Both groups are largely homogeneous in their religious practices, with most members adhering to Islam, and both speak Swahili. The third group is **Continental Africans in Zanzibar**, which encompasses African migrants who settled in Zanzibar and represents 1% of the total population.

State Profile

Official Language

Tanzania is home to over 120 linguistic groups. Its constitutions do not designate any specific language as the official language of the state. Swahili and English are the most commonly spoken languages; because Swahili is better known, it is more widely used for oral communication across the country.[11] English is primarily used for official documentation in mainland Tanzania, while Swahili is used in Zanzibar.[12]

Official Religion

Tanzania does not have an official state religion. Roughly half of the population adheres to Christianity, while the other half follows Islam.[13] Since religious affiliations are not recorded in official censuses, these estimates remain approximate.

Education Policies

The right to education is enshrined in the country's current Constitution of 1977, which guarantees that "every person has the right to self-education, and every citizen shall be free to pursue education in a field of his choice up to the highest level according to his merits and ability."[14] Private schools were nationalized in the 1960s and 1970s. However, a surge in primary education enrolment in mainland Tanzania led to the reintroduction of private secondary schools in the 1980s. Economic liberalization in 1994 further facilitated the expansion of private schooling to all levels, with instruction available in both Swahili and English.[15]

[10] AMAR, 2023.
[11] Ethnologue, 2024.
[12] L'aménagement linguistique dans le monde, 2024.
[13] The Association of Religion Data Archives, 2024.
[14] Constitution of the United Republic of Tanzania, 1977, Article 11.
[15] Chediel et al., 2000.

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Language Education Policies

At independence, Swahili became the primary language of instruction in primary schools, with English used in secondary and higher education. However, as these are not first languages for most of the population, many students do not learn to read and write in their mother tongue. In 2015, the government mandated that instruction in both primary and secondary schools should be conducted in Swahili, and in English afterwards. Although there is no specific legislation prohibiting the use of other languages as mediums of instruction, this is not widely implemented. In Zanzibar, where the government has significant autonomy over local policies, private schools, including madrassas and Qur'anic schools, use Arabic as the language of instruction.

Religious Education Policies

Schools in Tanzania offer religious education, with parents having the option to decide whether their children should attend. The Education Act of 1978 stipulates that "every school shall provide in its curriculum for the provision of religious instruction to its pupils on the premises of the school, but no pupil shall be compelled to attend any particular religious class."[16] Most schools offer a religious class in Christianity or Islam.

Demographic Engineering and Violence

Forced Relocations

There is no evidence of government-sponsored forced relocation policies targeting specific ethnic groups in Tanzania. However, indigenous groups such as the Maasai have experienced land grabbing and repossession by private companies.[17] Since this issue is not a state-sponsored policy, NBP does not include forced relocations of the Maasai. Additionally, the villagization policies implemented between 1968 and 1975 mandated the settlement of most of Tanzania's rural population into approximately 7,000 villages. According to government statistics, by 1976, 90% of the rural population had been relocated to these villages.[18] This policy does not meet the NBP dataset criteria for internal displacement of groups, however, as the

[16] The National Education Act, 1978, Article 56.
[17] Minority Rights, 2024b.
[18] Lorgen, 1999.

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targeted population was not a discrete ethnic group and there was no systematic removal of the affected population.

Constitutions and Laws

Since independence, Tanzania has had four constitutions in force: in 1961, 1962, 1965, and 1977. The 1961 Constitution is regarded as Tanzania's independence constitution, while the 1962 Constitution established the Republic. The 1965 Constitution, an interim constitution, formalized the union between Tanganyika and Zanzibar, creating the United Republic of Tanzania. The 1961, 1962, and 1965 constitutions do not mention any specific ethnic groups, nor do they include specific provisions for an official language or religion, but they all uphold freedom of religion. The 1977 Constitution further solidified these principles and explicitly affirmed the secular, socialist nature of the state, declaring that "Tanzania is governed by a Government that adheres to the principles of democracy and socialism and shall be a secular state."[19]

Citizenship Laws

No groups in Tanzania have historically been restricted from accessing citizenship. However, it is important to note that groups based in Zanzibar only gained Tanzanian citizenship from 1964 onwards, following the union of Zanzibar with Tanganyika to form the United Republic of Tanzania. Since 1995, birthright citizenship has been discontinued; now, only those born in Tanzania to at least one Tanzanian parent can automatically acquire citizenship.[20]

National Anthem(s)

Tanzania was the first African state to adopt the popular African religious hymn "God Bless Africa" as its national anthem in 1961, which continued to serve as its anthem after the union of Tanganyika and Zanzibar in 1964. The anthem is written in Swahili. It is filled with religious references and includes ambiguous references to nationhood.[21]

[19] Constitution of the United Republic of Tanzania, 1977, Preamble.
[20] Nambooze, 2020.
[21] National Anthems.info, 2024.

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